

Collapsi: Unofficial Rulebook

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Original game by Mark S. Ball

Unofficial Joker Edition with optional Revival Variations

Edition: Collapsi Revival Edition | Version 1.0.0

Objective

Move your pawn across the board as the cards behind you collapse.

The game ends as soon as a player cannot make a legal move.

The last player to complete a legal move wins.

Players

2 players

Optional larger-board rules are included for 3 and 4 players.

Components

For the standard 4 × 4 game, you need:

- 2 distinguishable pawns
- 2 different Jokers
- 4 Aces
- 4 Twos
- 4 Threes
- 2 Fours

16 cards total

An Ace counts as 1.

A Joker lets you move 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces.

Setup

Choose a Player 1.

Player 1 shuffles all 16 cards and deals them face up in a 4 × 4 grid.

The first Joker dealt is Player 1's starting card.

The second Joker is Player 2's starting card.

Each player places their pawn on their starting Joker.

Player 1 goes first.

Playing the Game

On your turn, the card under your pawn is your starting card.

Your starting card determines how many spaces you move:

- Ace: move exactly 1 space.
- 2: move exactly 2 spaces.
- 3: move exactly 3 spaces.
- 4: move exactly 4 spaces.
- Joker: move 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces.

After you complete your move, turn your starting card face down.

It has now collapsed.

You cannot move through or land on a collapsed card unless an optional rule specifically allows you to do so.

The face-up card where your pawn ends its move becomes your starting card for your next turn.

Movement

Move your pawn orthogonally:

- left,
- right,
- up,
- or down.

You cannot move diagonally.

You may change direction during your move.

For example, if you must move four spaces, you could move:

- up 1, then left 3;
- down 2, left 1, then up 1;
- or follow any other legal path totaling four spaces.

Wrapping Around the Board

The board wraps around at its edges.

If you move beyond the left edge, continue from the right edge of the same row.

If you move beyond the right edge, continue from the left edge of the same row.

Likewise, if you move beyond the top edge, continue from the bottom of the same column, and vice versa.

Movement Restrictions

During a single turn:

- You cannot move through the same card more than once.

- You cannot end your move on your starting card.
- You cannot end your move on a card occupied by another player's pawn.
- You cannot move through or land on a collapsed card.
- You must complete your full required move.

You may move through a card occupied by another player's pawn, but you cannot end your move there.

Collapsing Cards

After every successful move, turn the card where you started your turn face down.

That card collapses regardless of the route you took.

The card where you end your move remains face up and determines your movement on your next turn.

A Joker collapses just like any other starting card.

Ending the Game

If you cannot complete your required move legally, the game ends immediately.

You cannot make a partial move.

The last player to complete a legal move wins.

Optional Variations

The following rules change the way Collapsi plays.

Unless a variation says otherwise, all normal rules remain in effect.

Three-player Board

For 3 players, use a 5 × 5 board.

Use:

- 3 different Jokers
- 6 Aces
- 6 Twos
- 6 Threes
- 4 Fours

25 cards total

Shuffle all 25 cards and deal them face up in a 5 × 5 grid.

The first Joker dealt is Player 1's starting card.

The second Joker is Player 2's starting card.

The third Joker is Player 3's starting card.

Each player places their pawn on their starting Joker.

Player 1 goes first, followed by Player 2 and then Player 3.

A player who starts a turn on a Joker may move 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces.

Big Board

For 4 players, use a 6×6 board.

Use:

- 4 different Jokers
- 8 Aces
- 8 Twos
- 8 Threes
- 8 Fours

36 cards total

Shuffle all 36 cards and deal them face up in a 6×6 grid.

The first Joker dealt is Player 1's starting card, the second is Player 2's, and so on.

Each player places their pawn on their starting Joker.

If fewer than four players use the 6×6 board, turn any unused Jokers face down before play begins.

A player who starts a turn on a Joker may move 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces.

Shifting Board

At the end of your turn, after moving and collapsing your starting card, shift either the row or column containing your pawn by one space.

Choose:

- whether to shift the row or the column;
- and which direction to shift it.

Rows may shift left or right.

Columns may shift up or down.

Move every card in the chosen row or column together, whether face up or collapsed.

If a card is pushed beyond the current outer edge of the board, it remains in play in its new position.

It does not wrap around or leave the game.

This may extend the overall shape of the board beyond its original rectangular grid, leaving a gap on the opposite side.

As the game continues, gaps may appear in the board.

You cannot move through a gap.

When a row or column shifts, its gaps shift with it.

You may still wrap around the outer edges of the board.

Player's Choice

Players do not start on Jokers.

After dealing the board, turn all Jokers face down.

Player 1 chooses any face-up card as a starting position.

Player 2 then chooses a different face-up card.

With more players, continue in player order.

Play then proceeds normally.

Revival Variations

The following variations allow collapsed cards to return to play.

For normal play, use no more than one Revival Variation per game.

Combine multiple Revival Variations only if all players agree to experiment with them.

Each player's once-per-game Revival ability is tracked separately.

Joker Revival

Once per game, you may revive a collapsed Joker by ending your move on it.

Normally, you cannot enter a collapsed card. Joker Revival creates one exception.

If the final space of your required move is a collapsed Joker, you may use your Joker Revival.

Turn the Joker face up and end your move on it.

Your starting card collapses as normal.

On your next turn, you are starting on a Joker, so you may move 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces.

After that move, the revived Joker collapses as normal.

Restrictions

- The collapsed Joker must be the final space of your move.
- You cannot move through a collapsed Joker.
- You may revive any Joker, regardless of which player originally started on it.
- A Joker that was previously revived and later collapsed may be revived again by another player, provided that player has not yet used their own Joker Revival.
- Each player may use Joker Revival once per game.

Adjacent Revival

Once per game, you may revive a previously collapsed card next to the space where you end your move.

First, complete your move normally.

Then collapse your starting card as normal.

You may now use your Adjacent Revival.

Choose one collapsed card orthogonally adjacent to your pawn and turn it face up.

Your pawn stays where it is.

The revived card immediately returns to play and may be moved through or landed on normally.

Any player may use the revived card.

If the revived card is a Joker, a player who later starts a turn on it may move 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces.

Restrictions

- The revived card must be orthogonally adjacent to your pawn after your move.
- You cannot revive the card that collapsed during the current turn.
- Each player may use Adjacent Revival once per game.

Reconstruction

Once per game, you may restore one collapsed card by collapsing a different active card.

First, complete your move normally.

Then collapse your starting card as normal.

You may now use your Reconstruction.

Choose any collapsed card and turn it face up.

Then choose a different face-up card that contains no pawn and turn it face down.

The restored card immediately returns to play.

The card you sacrificed is now collapsed and cannot be moved through or landed on.

Restrictions

- You cannot collapse a card containing your own pawn.
- You cannot collapse a card containing another player's pawn.
- The card you restore and the card you collapse must be different cards.
- You may restore the card that collapsed during the current turn.
- Each player may use Reconstruction once per game.

You may restore a Joker with Reconstruction.

If a player later starts a turn on that Joker, they may move 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces.

Reconstruction changes the layout of the playable board without increasing the total number of active cards: one card returns to play while another collapses.

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[Collapsi](#) was invented by Mark S. Ball of Riffle Shuffle & Roll.

The downloadable original rulebook identifies itself as Collapsi v1.3.1 (last updated July 9, 2025). It uses two Jacks as starting cards and gives each Jack a one-space opening move. This unofficial edition deliberately uses two Jokers with a choice of 1, 2, 3, or 4 spaces and adds optional Revival Variations. No official Collapsi version number is claimed for this edition.

The Revival concept and the Revival Variations presented here were conceived by Johann Duscher (a.k.a. Jonny Dee) and are maintained in the [Collapsi rules repository](#).

If you publish, adapt, or create a variant derived from the Revival rules introduced in this version, please retain the following credits where applicable:

- Mark S. Ball — creator of Collapsi
- Johann Duscher (a.k.a. Jonny Dee) — originator of the Revival concept and Revival Variations

Variants that do not use or derive from these Revival rules do not require attribution to Johann Duscher.

The original designer asks web apps and 3D-printable implementations to remain demonetized and always free to play. Credit Mark Ball as the designer, link to the [official Collapsi page](#), and, where possible, link to the [Riffle Shuffle & Roll YouTube channel](#).

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